

stock market circles, but out here, he was just another patron looking to have a good time over good food.

‘If it is so easy, why don’t you get us a table?’ Viren said.

‘Are you challenging me?’ Harshad asked.

‘Yes.’

To cut a long story short, Harshad managed to get us a seat without much delay. He did that by posing as a tour operator to the steward at the door allotting the tables. Harshad first told the steward to take good care of a group of twelve in the waiting list (he figured that by peeping into the steward’s notepad). He said they were wealthy diamond merchants from Gujarat and that he had specifically recommended this place to them. A little later, he again walked up to the steward and said he had another group of guests more important than the first group and that they be given priority. I was quite impressed with Harshad’s street smartness, but at the same time I suspected that he would not be averse to pulling off something similar at a bigger level if it helped him get ahead.

I do not have much recollection of that dinner, except that I chose a seat as far away from Harshad as possible. I was worried that he would pop me some questions on the market, and that I would say something silly in reply.

Still, he sought me out and asked me something about a company. I was self-conscious, and mumbled something. He heard me out attentively and then asked a counter-question.

‘True, Lala, but what if you were to look at it in a different way. Assume that . . .’

I responded with some more drivel, anxious that he should not question me further because I now had nothing more to say.

‘Hmm . . . you may have a point,’ he said, with a thoughtful look, as though I had presented him with an entirely new perspective.

As we parted after dinner, Harshad put his arm around my shoulder and said, ‘You seem to be an interesting fellow, Lala. Let’s keep in touch.’

He gave me his visiting card and asked me to ring him whenever I had interesting ideas.

A couple of weeks after that dinner meeting I started doing trades for Harshad. Sharma was my link to him, and all the orders would be relayed through him. It was mostly to buy shares; sometimes with a price-limit instruction, and at other times being allowed a free hand. I was doing all these deals in my capacity as a jobber and not as a dealer for my firm. Still,